“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 16

The Lord’s Youthful Pastimes

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I worship Lord Caitanya. Though the river of His nectarean mercy floods the whole world, it always shines as a river flowing downward — toward the lowly.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 May the youthful Caitanya be glorious! When He entered household life, Lakṣmī in person worshiped Him; and then, on the pretext of His victory over the conqueror of all directions, the goddess of speech worshiped Him too.

4 This is the outline, in *sūtras*, of His *kaiśora* (youthful) pastimes: He began to teach students.

5 He was always teaching, with hundreds upon hundreds of students around Him, and everyone who heard His explanations was astonished.

6 In every scripture every scholar met defeat at His hands, yet His manner was so courteous that no one was hurt.

7 With His students He played all kinds of high-spirited pranks, and He sported in the waters of the Jāhnavī (the Gaṅgā) in many playful ways.

8 Some days later the Lord went to Vaṅga (East Bengal). Wherever He went, He had people take up the congregational chanting of the holy name.

9 Seeing the power of His learning, people marveled at heart, and hundreds upon hundreds of students came to study with Him.

10 In that land lived a brāhmaṇa named Tapana Miśra. He could not settle what the goal of life (*sādhya*) is, nor the means of attaining it (*sādhana*).

11 Many scriptures and many opinions bewildered his mind, and he could not be sure which goal and which means are the highest.

12 In a dream a brāhmaṇa told him, “Listen, Tapana: go to Nimāi Paṇḍita.

13 He will settle for you the goal and the means. He is the Lord Himself — there is no doubt about it.”

14 After this dream Miśra came to the Lord’s feet and told Him the whole dream.

15 Pleased, the Lord told him the goal and the means. He instructed him: “Perform the congregational chanting of the holy name.”

16 Tapana Miśra wished to live with the Lord in Navadvīpa, but the Lord ordered him, “Go to Vārāṇasī.

17 There you will meet Me.” Receiving this order, Miśra went to Kāśī.

18 I cannot understand the Lord’s endless pastimes: why does He deprive Miśra of His company and send him to the city of Kāśī?

19 In this way He did good to all the people of Vaṅga: by giving them the holy name He made them devotees, and by teaching them He made them scholars.

20 While the Lord performed various pastimes in Vaṅga, here in Navadvīpa Lakṣmī grew sorrowful in separation from Him.

21 The serpent of separation from the Lord bit Lakṣmī, and by the venom of that serpent she departed for the other world.

22 The Lord knew of it within, for He knows every heart. Knowing Śacī's grief, He returned to His homeland.

23 The Lord came home bringing much wealth and many followers, and by speaking the truth He dispelled Śacī's grief.

24 Again He delighted in learning with His students; conquering everyone by the strength of His learning, He displayed a scholar's pride.

25 Then came His marriage with Viṣṇupriyā Ṭhākurāṇī, and after that the Lord conquered the *digvijayī* (the conqueror of all directions).

26 Vṛndāvana dāsa has described this in detail, but he did not set out clearly the analysis of the faults and merits.

27 Bowing to him, I shall tell that part — hearing it, the *digvijayī* reproached himself.

28 One moonlit night the Lord was sitting with His students on the bank of the Gaṅgā, discussing points of learning.

29 Just then the *digvijayī* arrived there. After offering prayers to the Gaṅgā, he met the Lord.

30 The Lord respectfully gave him a seat, and the *digvijayī*, inwardly contemptuous, said:

31 “You teach grammar, and Your name is Nimāi Paṇḍita. People speak of Your many virtues in the children’s science (*bālya-śāstra*, grammar).

32 Among the grammars, I know, You teach the *Kalāpa*. I have heard Your students talking in tricky verbal puzzles (*phāṅki*).”

33 The Lord said, “I teach grammar — so I fancy. But My students do not understand, and I cannot make them understand.

34 What comparison is there between you, expert in all the scriptures and in poetry, and Me — a mere child, a novice student?

35 I would like to hear some of your poetry, if you would kindly describe the Gaṅgā.”

36 Hearing this, the brāhmaṇa proudly began, and within a single *ghaṭī* (twenty-four minutes) he described the Gaṅgā in a hundred verses.

37 When He had heard them, the Lord honored him greatly: “On earth there is no other poet like you.

38 Who has the power to understand the verses of your poem? Only you know their meaning well — or Sarasvatī.

39 If you yourself explain the meaning of one verse, everyone will hear it with great delight.”

40 Then the *digvijayī* asked which verse to explain, and the Lord recited one of the hundred verses.

41 “This greatness of the Gaṅgā ever shines supreme, for she is blessed by her origin from the lotus feet of Śrī Viṣṇu. Like a second Śrī Lakṣmī, she has feet worshiped by gods and men; and she, of wondrous qualities, flourishes on the head of Bhavānī’s husband.”

42 When the Lord said, “Explain the meaning of this verse,” the *digvijayī* was astonished and asked Him:

43 “I recited the verses like a storm wind. How did You learn one of them by heart?”

44 The Lord said, “By the boon of a deity you are the best of poets; likewise, by the boon of a deity someone may become a *śruti-dhara*, one who retains whatever he hears.”

45 Pleased, the brāhmaṇa explained the meaning of the verse. The Lord said, “Now tell Me its merits and faults.”

46 The brāhmaṇa said, “No fault appears in the verse. Its merits are the ornament of simile (*upamā*) and some alliteration (*anuprāsa*).”

47 The Lord said, “I will say something, if you will not be angry. Tell Me, what fault is there in this verse of yours?

48 Your inspired words please the deity; yet when they are carefully examined, their merits and faults become known.

49 So examine the verse carefully.” The poet said, “The verse You have recited is the very essence of the Vedas.

50 You are a grammarian; You have not studied poetics (*alaṅkāra*). What could You know of the essence of this poetry?”

51 The Lord said, “That is why I am asking you: examine its merits and faults and explain them to Me.

52 I have not studied poetics, but I have heard about it; so I see many faults and merits in this verse.”

53 The poet said, “Well then, tell me — what merits and what faults?” The Lord said, “I will tell you; listen, and do not be angry.

54 In this verse there are five faults and five ornaments. I will name them in order; listen and judge.

55 An ill-placed predicate (*avimṛṣṭa-vidheyāṁśa*) appears in two places, and there are three more faults: a contradictory sense (*viruddha-mati*), a broken sequence (*bhagna-krama*), and the resumption of a completed sentence (*punar-ātta*).

56 In the verse, “the greatness of the Gaṅgā” is the main predicate (*vidheya*), and the subject (*anuvāda*), the word *idam* (“this”), is expressed only afterward.

57 You stated the predicate first and the subject afterward, and for this reason the meaning of the verse has been lost.

58 “One should not state the predicate without first stating the subject, for nothing without a footing can stand firm anywhere.” (Ekādaśī-tattva 13)

59 In “a second Śrī Lakṣmī,” the predicate is “secondness” (*dvitīyatva*). In the compound it became subordinate, and the meaning of the words was lost.

60 The word *dvitīya* (“second”) is the predicate, yet it fell into the compound, and that destroyed the meaning “equality with Lakṣmī.”

61 This fault is called *avimṛṣṭa-vidheyāṁśa*. Now hear attentively another fault.

62 You were pleased to use the word *bhavānī-bhartuḥ* (“of Bhavānī’s husband”), but this is a grave fault named *viruddha-mati-kṛt*, “that which produces a contradictory sense.”

63 The word *bhavānī* means the wife of Mahādeva. When you name her husband, one understands a second husband.

64 “The husband of Śiva’s wife” sounds contradictory. In the science of poetics a word that produces a contradictory sense is not correct.

65 “Give charity into the hand of the husband of the brāhmaṇa’s wife” — as soon as one hears these words, the idea of a second husband arises.

66 With the verb *vibhavati* (“flourishes”) the sentence is complete; then comes another adjective, *adbhuta-guṇā* (“of wondrous qualities”). This is the fault *punar-ātta*, resuming a completed sentence.

67 In three lines I see matchless alliteration, but in one line there is none: this is the fault *bhagna-krama*, a broken sequence.

68 Although this verse has five ornaments, these five faults have ruined it.

69 Even if a verse has ten ornaments, a single fault destroys them all.

70 It is as with a beautiful body decked with ornaments: a single spot of white leprosy makes it contemptible.

71 “Poetry full of *rasa* and ornaments, if it has a fault, is like a beautiful, well-adorned body made unsightly by a single spot of white leprosy.”

72 Now hear the analysis of the five ornaments: two are ornaments of sound (*śabdālaṅkāra*) and three are ornaments of sense (*arthālaṅkāra*).

73 The ornaments of sound are the alliteration in three lines and, in the words *śrī-lakṣmī*, the apparent repetition (*punar-uktavad-ābhāsa*).

74 In the first line there is a row of five *t*'s, and in the third line five *r*'s are placed.

75 In the fourth line the letter *bh* appears four times. So the alliteration is an ornament of sound.

76 The word *śrī* and the word *lakṣmī* state one and the same thing; it seems almost a repetition, yet it is not a repetition.

77 In the sense "Lakṣmī endowed with beauty (*śrī*)" the meanings differ. This apparent repetition (*punar-uktavad-ābhāsa*) is a kind of ornament of sound.

78 In *lakṣmīr iva* ("like Lakṣmī") a simile (*upamā*) appears — an ornament of sense. There is another ornament of sense, called *virodhābhāsa*, apparent contradiction.

79 "The lotus grows in the Gaṅgā" — everyone readily understands that. But "the Gaṅgā is born in a lotus" is a glaring contradiction.

80 Here, the Gaṅgā arises from the lotus feet of Viṣṇu: this ornament of contradiction is wonderfully striking.

81 The Gaṅgā became manifest by the inconceivable power of the Lord, so there is no real contradiction here — only the semblance of one.

82 “The lotus is born in water; nowhere is water born from a lotus. But in the slayer of Mura it is the reverse: from His lotus feet the great river was born.”

83 The greatness of the Gaṅgā is what is to be proved (*sādhya*), and its proof (*sādhana*) is her origin from Viṣṇu’s feet: this is the ornament *anumāna*, inference.

84 These are only the obvious five faults and five ornaments; if I examine the verse subtly, there are countless more.

85 Your genius and poetic gift come by the grace of the deity, but poetry that is not examined surely falls prey to faults.

86 When poetry is examined, it becomes spotless, and when it also has ornaments, its meaning sparkles.”

87 Hearing the Lord’s words, the *digvijayī* was astonished. No word came from his mouth; his genius was stunned.

88 He wanted to say something, but no answer came. Then, perplexed, he reflected within:

89 “A schoolboy has robbed me of my wits. I see that Sarasvatī is angry with me.

90 No human being has the power to give such an explanation. Sarasvatī herself is speaking from Nimāi’s mouth.”

91 Thinking this, he said, “Listen, Nimāi Paṇḍita: hearing Your explanation, I am astonished.

92 You have not studied poetics, nor have You practiced the scriptures. How did You bring out all these meanings?”

93 Hearing this, Mahāprabhu, who loves to play, knew his heart and answered playfully:

94 “I do not know what is good or bad in analyzing the scriptures. I speak whatever words Sarasvatī makes Me speak.”

95 Hearing this, the *digvijayī* concluded: “The goddess has defeated me through a child.

96 Today I shall chant her mantra, meditate on her, and put this before her: through a child she has humiliated me so.”

97 In truth, Sarasvatī herself had made him compose a faulty verse, and when it was analyzed she covered his intelligence.

98 Then all the students began to laugh. The Lord stopped them and said to the poet:

99 “You are a great scholar, the crown jewel of poets, for such poetry flows from your mouth.

100 Your poetry is like the stream of the Gaṅgā’s waters; nowhere do I see another poet like you.

101 Faults appear even in the poetry of Bhavabhūti, Jayadeva and Kālidāsa.

102 In the analysis of faults and merits I consider this a small matter; it is the power to compose poetry that I praise.

103 Please take no offense at My childish impudence; I am not even the equal of your disciple.

104 Go to your lodging today; tomorrow we shall meet again, and I shall hear you discuss the scriptures.”

105 So both of them went home, and that night the poet worshiped Sarasvatī.

106 In the night Sarasvatī instructed him, and he came to know the Lord as the Supreme Lord Himself.

107 In the morning he came and took shelter at the Lord’s feet. The Lord showed him mercy and cut his bonds.

108 Fortunate was the *digvijayī*, and his life fruitful: through the strength of his learning he attained Mahāprabhu’s feet.

109 Vṛndāvana dāsa has described all these pastimes; what little I have done here is to bring out particular points.

110 The pastimes of Caitanya Gosāñi are a stream of nectar; hearing them satisfies all the senses.

111 Hoping for the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, Kṛṣṇadāsa tells the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.